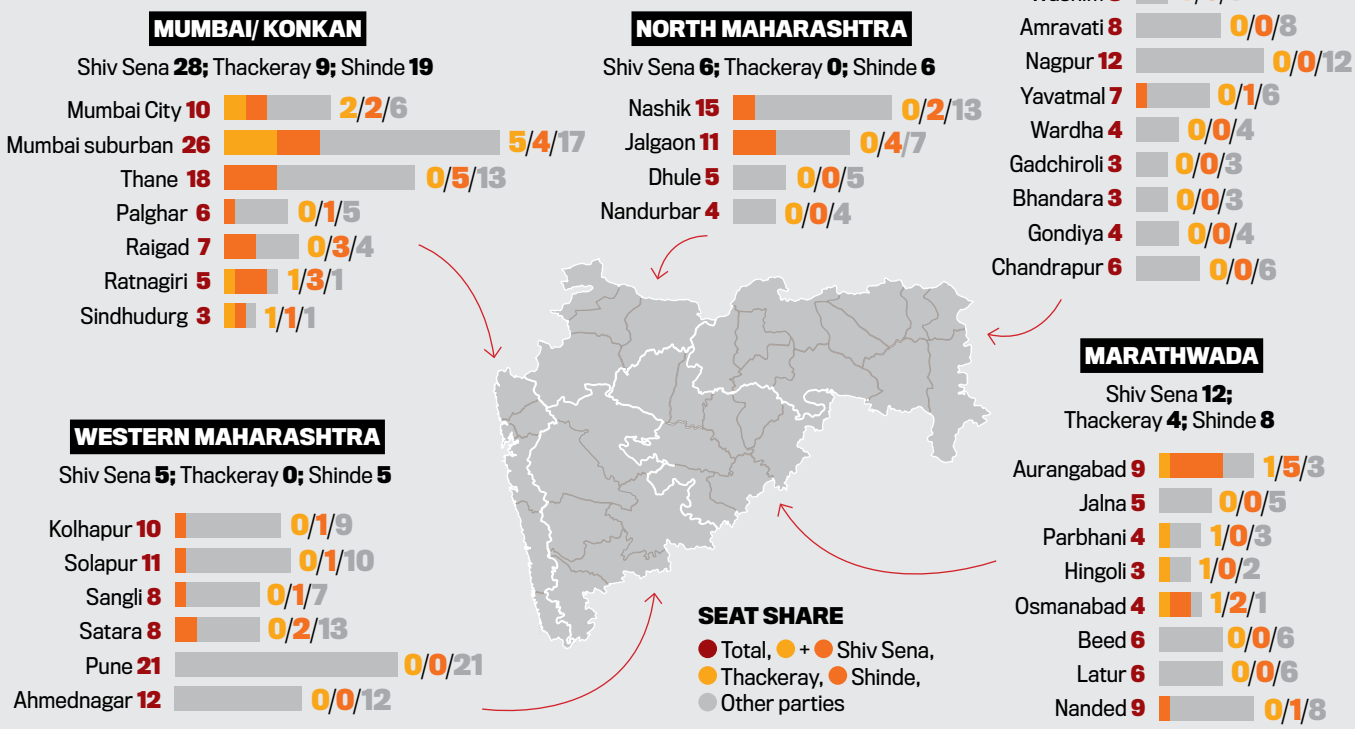
SENA IN A SNAPSHOT

Shinde has assured support of Sena MLAs from all over Maharashtra. Even in the Sena's Mumbai-Konkan heart, the rebel camp is ahead 2 to 1 against the Thackerays



Graphic by TANMOY CHAKRABORTY

building political networks beyond Thane. "Many people were surprised when 40 MLAs backed Shinde over Uddhav. The secret lies in the medical services," says a member of the cell.

It now transpires that Uddhav had a premonition about a possible revolt by Shinde—except he under-estimated its scale. A source close to Uddhav says the CM had started keeping tabs on Shinde's movements. "Uddhavji had asked me and a few other people to collect information on all of Shinde's meetings. He always had a doubt that Shinde might ditch him one day." Shinde offered the first hint of an autonomous future on his birthday, February 9, when he took 16 Sena MLAs with him to meet Uddhav. Ostensibly, he was seeking his blessings; in reality, it was a show of strength that Uddhav failed to read.

Fadnavis was watching the goings-on with much interest. He had kept up his rapport with Shinde, inter alia sharing insights pertaining to Mumbai's infrastructure. Sometime in early 2022, Fadnavis is believed to have approached Shinde, sussing out the possibility of him being able to lull away at least 37 MLAs—the number necessary for a split in the legislative party. This was just three months after Fadnavis had denied any poaching expedition to INDIA TODAY. "There is no Shinde on our side," he had said last November, when asked if the BJP was looking at inducting "another Shinde"—Jyotiraditya Scindia, still called by his non-anglicised named 'Shinde' in these parts, had joined the BJP by then. But by June, after Fadnavis managed the cross-voting from Sena MLAs in the Rajya Sabha and council elections, he probably realised the time for 'Operation Shinde' had come.

The BJP, having burnt its fingers once with a 78-hour government in 2019, proceeded with abundant caution this time, staying in the backdrop, preferring to let the fortress be breached from within, only offering 'logistical' help. The decision to seek a floor test—rather than move a no-confidence motion—came on the back of intense legal scrutiny of possible repercussions. At that stage, the legal fate of the rebel MLAs was still up in the air, and the BJP wanted no egg in the face in the event of a subsequent disqualification. But the way the events unfolded sui generis proved advantageous for the party. "Shinde brought down the MVA regime on the steam of his own rebellion," a party